

KHMER ROUGE LEADER, 1928–98

POL POT

Born near Kompong Thom in May 1928, Saloth Sar emerged onto the political scene in 1953, and rose to become secretary general of Cambodia's secret Communist Party in 1963. The leader of the Khmer Rouge guerrillas, he became prime minister after Phnom Penh fell in 1975. He adopted his revolutionary name, Pol Pot, in 1976.

After Vietnam invaded Cambodia, Pol Pot went to Thailand. He relinquished his army in 1985 and lived a shadowy life until his death in 1998. Many details about his life remain shrouded in secrecy.



» AFTER

Although Vietnam had sponsored the Khmer Rouge originally, Hanoi's politburo never ceased wanting to annex Cambodia.

POWER CHANGES HANDS

After many mutual provocations, on December 25, 1978, Vietnam **invaded Cambodia**. By the beginning of January, they had ousted Pol Pot and replaced the Khmer Rouge with a Vietnamese **puppet regime**. However, the Khmer Rouge continued to fight the Vietnamese, and its guerrilla forces returned once more to bases in the jungles.



KHMER ROUGE GUERRILLAS